

Name: Raheek Muhammad Raiyan

ID: 21301282

Section: 03

My Family History of 1971

History is something that historians write about a definite time frame based on the information that sometimes might be just like the “upper water surface of an ocean”. There are various dynamic factors that we usually do not take into account while reading or writing about the history of any certain thing. It has some deeper and darker sides if we consider different perspectives of the slice of life of the people of different classes. But the lack of these unknown sides or stories of a history, creates a void in the record of history which generally tends to exclude the stories of the lower class population. So to understand the deeper sides of history, there is a necessity to consider the voice and stories of the survival of the local ones which is the main motivation of this assignment.

The person I interviewed is my maternal grandmother, Ruby Chowdhuri, who was born around 1953 in Mirshorai district, Chittagong. She was a housewife during the time of our liberation war and belonged to a middle class family and her husband, my maternal grandfather, was a government service holder in Customs.

At the time of our liberation war, she was residing in Dhaka beside Dhaka College with her husband as he was a government service holder and he was transferred to Dhaka. The horrifying night of 25th March was clearly imaginable from her voice in the interview. From her sayings, the slaughtering and the killing started with Dhaka University as she mentioned that they could not sleep properly that night due to the fear of getting attacked any time. Different halls and slums were set on fire and different places were set on fire. People were running wherever they felt it might be safe as curfew was declared all over the country. Even when curfew was almost over or there was just a few minutes left, the Pakistani army did not back off rather they shot as many as they could to death. The killing spree was so terrifying that it shook the whole country.

The people were scared to the core and as she said that her husband would go to office if he felt safe, we can say that even the government officers would be threatened if they did not cooperate with the Pakistani army in their invasion. Moreover, the army raid was not anything new at that time and people were fleeing wherever they could for the safety of their life.

Mass murder also took place if the Pakistani army suspected anything or they thought anyone might rebel. As in the interview, she said while fleeing from Dhaka to Faridpur on 28th of March, got to know that the army were even destroying the vehicles, taking down the Bangalees, slaughtering them and throwing the dead bodies in the water bodies. But the main thing to be noted is, the situation of Dhaka was not as that of other places of East Pakistan and the

villagers suffered the most as we know it's always the low class people who suffer the most and are exploited and ultimately they are the ones who revolt against all the odds with the brain of the middle-class.

The army tried to exterminate every way so that the Bangalees could not stand against them thus they killed anyone of age between 20-30 years old captured and tortured to death. And women were one of the most tortured and sexually harassed and got unnoticed as the social system instead accused the molested women for being molested which led them to commit suicide. This is the dark phase of 1971. Another section of people were the Hindus. The situation of the Hindus was like shoot at sight. Killing Hindus was like "Jihad" for the Pakistani army which is basically the misuse of the religion for their own cause. They left for India crossing the borders. About 10 million people took refuge in India during that time. They even got no chance to hold any important festivals of Hindus like Pujas etc. It was more like life over everything else for them as they had a very slight chance of surviving as she says, "the Hindus were in constant fear of getting killed". Even the marriage ceremonies in Muslim families took place with a limited number of people. Even some Muslims also hesitated to give them shelter and they were the "Rajakars" who also snatched away the properties of the Hindus.

There were a number of peace committees formed around the country though from the interview consisting of about 10-12 persons, it could be known that there were not that many peace committees formed in Dhaka and it is quite logical as these committees were village oriented and as the Pakistani army did not know Bangla language and they were unfamiliar with our roads and ways. The main reason for making the Peace committees was to help the Pakistani armed forces to maintain the integrity of Pakistan.

The "Mukti bahini " or the freedom fighters were the key to our victory during the liberation war. Most of the Mukti Fouj were the local ones who dedicated their life for their country and their area and some were from different areas as it's said in the interview. Almost in every family, there were mukti fouj. The Muktu Fouj and the Hindus were kind of on the same page for the Pakistani Army and both were considered as traitors and were tortured to death mercilessly.

But one thing that is mentionable is that, despite all these going on in the country, the price of the daily necessary commodities was not too high or less. There was no such news of anyone dying because of starvation as it's said in the interview mainly in town. It's true that we still do not know if the low class people died or not as it did not make it to the headline as she says, "the army disturbed the villagers most by invading the houses of the villagers whenever they wanted and torturing the villagers". But the general picture from the interview indicates that shortage of food was not a problem at that time. So, we can easily assume that the war was mainly fought by the villagers or the lower class who had nowhere to go and were exploited to their last limit by the army. Thus war for freedom was their last resort.

Amid all those mixed emotions of despair and dreaming of victory, the Eid-UI-Fitr arrived. The Eid took place in the month November as she says in the interview, and everything seemed

somewhat normal in the town(Dhaka) but the main movements started just after Eid where. Though everything was normal, no one bought new clothes. In an article, Jahanara Imam said, "That year, freedom fighters did not celebrate Eid. All they hoped for was **Bijoyer Eid.**"

Then came the most awaited, the victory of Bangladesh, 16 December. On one hand, there were tears of joy while on the other hand, there were howling in agony for the lost ones. In the interview, she said when asked about the celebration of the victory, "I was in the village at that time and there was no such joyful moment that could be noticed in the village." One thing that can be clearly said from this is that the losses in these whole 9 months were so much that the pain was greater than the victory itself and still people all over the country tried to enjoy as they could despite all these losses.

Then comes one of the hardest chapters of the post liberation war, the chapter of rebuilding a new country. From the words in the interview, we can easily assume that it was one of the tough phases, if not the toughest. On one hand there were heavy hearts all over the country, then came a new problem of robbers, dacoits, muggers, bandits. Even some freedom fighters also chose this path to earn their bread. Some misused the power and exploited it. As she said in the interview, "People passed every night in fear of getting robbed or killed. The news of getting robbed or killed became common. Many innocents died." Thus we can get the glimpse of the war ravaged country where the economy ceased to function, demolition of the infrastructure and being on the verge of famine along with the rise of political difficulties. It is said that the main challenge after forming a new country is its rebuilding, which gave a hard time to the political leaders and took almost 2 years to calm down the situation.

The case study of my grandmother expresses the story of the people in town and a view of people from the villages, about the story of the exploitation of the people, the vengeance from the resisting force of the people. Though the story varies from the ones we get to know from the formal part of war in books, the perspective I got to see revealing the attitudes of the Pakistani army and the frightful condition of the people due to the conflict, enhances my understanding of the liberation war. We should get to know about both the inclusive and exclusive parts of any history as the clear view can only be achieved if we get to know about different perspectives. This is beyond any conventional knowledge of textbooks which is more practical, mixed with true emotions and logics.